authorities and lastly, to inform the next of kin of the injured person. Illogical bravado must always be avoided. As an example, fighting alone with a number of hoodlums on seeing them teasing a girl, or jumping into a river to save someone when the situation states that you are a non-swimmer will get you nothing but a negative assessment. One must remain realistic and take only calculated risks when writing one's responses. But empathy and moral responsibility towards society should be kept in mind.

All I remember was that I focused on organizing my thoughts while writing my responses and made sure to keep the basics in mind. I ended up writing fifty-five responses before Sqn Ldr Yadav asked us to put our pens down. I looked around to see most faces disappointed. But I was fairly content with my performance, though I didn't know how it would be judged. Next was the SD. We were required to write on a blank sheet of paper what we felt our family members, friends and teachers thought about us. Both the positive aspects of our personality and the areas we felt needed improvement were required to be mentioned. By the time the digital clock read '0900h', the tests were done.

'*O devare*, I've never written so many stories ever in my life before,' Hema said as we walked out of the examination hall. 'I can be a novelist now.'

'Yes, but please don't write anything on psychology. I've had my share of it in just a day,' I said, and we laughed.

'Everyone, proceed for breakfast, please,' Deepa announced to the scattered groups of girls. We headed for the mess. It was the day I learnt how hungry mental exhaustion could make you feel. I'd never really worried much about exams and tests back in school or college, but this wasn't just an exam or a test. My dreams, and Papaji's, were at stake.

'Why is everyone reading and mugging up?' I asked Hema at the breakfast table. There was silence inside the mess and most of the tables had more notes laid out than plates. Almost every girl had her face buried in the pages of either handwritten notes or textbooks. And there I was, deciding whether to eat my toast with butter or with fruit jam. 'I don't know,' Hema said, equally clueless.